

but you can ask the OS not to load the modules onto the RAM, and mount them in loop mode, instead, with the `CDL_LOOP` kernel parameter. After it boots in, you will get the same smooth performance as the standard edition, once you reach the desktop.

I started with the multimedia section, which is the deciding factor for me in selecting an OS for general desktop use. I found *Livestation 2.7.0* for *livetv* and radio broadcasts, which replaced *Gmlive* from *v0.9.3*, two front ends of *Mplayer*, the *Mplayer GUI* and *SMPlayer*, and a burner called *Xfburn*. The audio and video experience was pretty good as the support of non-free codecs was out-of-the-box. The Internet menu revealed a lot of applications including *Firefox 3.5.1*, *Pidgin* and *Slypheed* – other additions are *Skype2.0*, *Filezilla*, *aMule*, etc. The redundant *Opera* in *v0.9.2* was removed in *0.9.3*. *Zoho* is used as the office suite, but *GNumeric*, a spreadsheet application is also included. The *0.9.3* version has a new addition — *KchmViewer*, a compiled HTML viewer. *Printer* support was lacking in the standard edition. The community edition comes with *CUPS* and printers can now be configured. You can also configure a wireless network with the help of *wicd* (not in the standard edition).

The strange part is that this edition comes with the *Avast* anti-virus, home edition, though you need to register with *avast.com* and get a free personal-use serial number to activate it. With *TestDisk* from the standard edition, the community edition also comes with the popular *Partimage* and *Gparted* partition managers, making partitioning easy.

And of course, it has a *Games* section containing *Minesweeper*, card games, and *DOSBox*. *DOSBox* is not a game but a *DOS* emulator. It often comes into the 'games' category because of its usefulness in running classic games like *Alladin*, *Prince of Persia*, *Invaders*, *Wolfenstein*, etc.

We now have *GCC (v3.4.6)*, as it now (*v0.9.3*) supports compiling the official Linux kernel and also additional modules and drivers.

Check out the full list of applications of the CDlinux Community Edition at CDlinux.info/wiki/doku.php/releases/0.9.2/packages

Customisation

The main attraction of CDlinux is that it provides an operating system with the latest Linux kernel, drivers and a bare-minimum set of applications that are updated and stable. CDlinux provides the base of the operating system on which you can add building blocks to make a complete OS that exactly matches your needs. This is unlike others like *Puppy Linux* and *Slitaz CDlinux* that currently do not have any 'remaster' tools. To add customised packages to CDlinux, it needs to make/download the *squashfs* *md* images of the applications and place them in the 'local' directory of the CDlinux

directory hierarchy to be auto-detected by CDlinux. This is just like the *puppy.sfs* *squashfs* packages. Even desktop environments other than *Xfce* can be used on top of the *Mini* edition. Because CDlinux doesn't have any repository as of now, *.md* packages are not available easily and one has to make or hack them from the community edition. Though this might not be very customisable for general users, it definitely is very interesting for geeks. As CDlinux approaches the 1.0 release, we can expect CDlinux repositories to become available with *.md* packages.

CDlinux provides some boot parameters that are very easy and extremely useful. Check out *CDlinux.info/wiki/doku.php/doc/faq/cdl_options* for details on boot parameters.

Support

This is where CDlinux lets you down. According to Zhao, there is documentation and support for CDlinux, but mostly in Chinese, so it is of no use if it is not translated for non-Chinese users. You will get very little documentation for CDlinux customisation. Older documentation relevant to the 0.4 release of CDlinux can be found in CDlinux.info/archive/0.4/howto.html. There is no dedicated forum or an IRC channel. According to Zhao, new documentation is being written.

Gazing into the crystal ball

When I asked Zao what his favourite feature of CDlinux was, this was what he said:

"Yes, CDlinux is stable and up to date, and it is compact. The features and libs/apps of CDlinux are carefully selected. We only ship stable and usable applications — no flashy ones. CDlinux is clean. In fact, we are very proud of CDlinux — there is too much to talk about, like it can be run in memory, which has been a feature of CDlinux since its birth. I think the best feature of CDlinux is its *i18n* support. CDlinux supports *i18n* for all major languages/locales (over 100). Although for size considerations, *i10n* support is limited, users can easily extend CDlinux to support *i10n* for their own language/locale. Many applications are fine tuned/patched, e.g., if you use *Midnight Commander* (my favourite file manager), you'll find that the version in CDlinux is the best. Cheers!" 

Links:

- Official website: CDlinux.info
- FAQs: CDlinux.info/wiki/doku.php/doc/faq/index

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